COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Co-Founder at Enigma Believes *Procurement* Platforms Like *Zip*, *Omnea*, and Pivot Lack Customizability and Warns Against Vendor Lock-In

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SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The conversation covered a detailed evaluation of procurement technology vendors, focusing on product capabilities, customization, integration, user experience, and vendor interactions. The expert compared the strengths and weaknesses of Omnea, Zip, and Pivot, and discussed broader industry trends around platform versus point solution strategies and the role of AI in procurement tools.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Co-founder with extensive experience evaluating and implementing ***procurement*** technology solutions at multiple technology companies, including leading ***procurement*** modernization and tool selection processes.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Believes that modern ***procurement*** platforms like ***Zip***, ***Omnea***, and Pivot all provide solid intake solutions, but none offer exceptional customizability or fully meet advanced needs without additional in-house development.
- Expresses **skepticism** about relying on a single vendor for all procurement needs due to concerns about vendor lock-in, pricing practices, and lack of flexibility, preferring a modular approach with the ability to build or integrate custom solutions.
- Views AI features as valuable only when deeply embedded and genuinely improving workflow, rather than as superficial add-ons.

TAKEAWAYS

- The expert evaluated Omnea, Zip, and Pivot, focusing on user experience, customizability, integration capabilities, and cost, with a particular need for integration with Workday's finance module.
- **All three platforms are seen as strong for intake orchestration**, but differ in depth and market focus: Pivot is best suited for smaller companies, Omnea for mid-market with AI and supplier focus, and Zip is positioned as the enterprise leader with broader features and higher pricing.
- Customization of user interfaces and workflows is limited across all platforms, with none allowing significant tailoring beyond standard forms and logic; **this was a key shortcoming for the expert**.
- Sales and vendor interactions varied: Pivot offered a direct, informal approach; **Omnea was respectful but engaged in negative competitor talk**; Zip's process was formal, difficult to access product trials, and marked by aggressive sales tactics and inconsistent pricing.
- **The expert values vendors with similar customer profiles, transparent and supportive sales and support teams, and a demonstrated commitment to ongoing product innovation, but is wary of high funding levels without profitability and founders** lacking procurement backgrounds.

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Table of Contents

Introduction and Vendor Overview

Evaluation Criteria and Vendor Comparison

User Experience and Customization Insights

Enterprise Features and Market Trends

Sales Experience and Vendor Interactions

Competitor Dynamics and Vendor Reputation

Industry Insights and Future Competitiveness

AI Features and Market Readiness

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Expert Bio

Co-Founder at Enigma, a modern procurement agency helping tech companies manage massive spend. Senior Manager of Procurement at Personio. The expert has been actively involved in evaluating multiple procurement technology providers, participating in numerous demos and conversations as part of a broad vendor review. They acted as both the key decision maker and evaluator, overseeing the assessment process, shaping buying criteria, and evaluating offerings, capabilities, and fit, though no solution has been purchased to date. They are able to discuss the relative strengths and weaknesses, as well as pricing and packaging considerations, based on these evaluations and how different factors mattered to their organization. Co-Founder at Enigma, a modern procurement agency helping tech companies manage massive spend with lean teams and zero bloat. The expert builds efficient, in-house operations using AI and low-code tools so you can do more with less. The expert is responsible for Modern Procurement Strategy (agile frameworks that control costs without the red tape), In-House Automation & AI (custom workflows, vendor onboarding, and AI agents built directly in your stack), and Lean Operations Design (restructuring buying processes for speed and efficiency). Senior Manager of Procurement at Personio. The expert is responsible for leading procurement operations at europe's most valuable HR SaaS tech company, founded 2015, valued at $8.5bn.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Thank you in for taking the time to speak about the procurement technology space and some of these new market entrants. Just to get us started, confirm the vendors that you evaluated. I know that you've looked at Omnea, Pivot and Levelpath. Is that correct or are there any others that we should add to the list?

Expert 00:00:19

It was Omnea, Zip, Pivot. With Levelpath, I had one demo out of curiosity and interest, but we were not really evaluating as a solution. I just wanted to see what they're doing.

Client 00:00:35

Got you. Perhaps then we can keep our conversation focused on Omnea, Zip and Pivot. I guess we'll probably speak a bit mostly about your experience at Personio, but obviously we can speak more broadly too, no worries. I was curious, when you started the evaluation, looking at these vendors, what was the trigger for that? Was it modernization? Was it dissatisfaction with current tools, something else? What started that evaluation for you guys?

Expert 00:01:07

I think we've been across Personio, my previous company, in three evaluation phases, let's say. At my previous company, four or five years ago, this is when this whole intake orchestration thing started. It's right around the time when ***Zip*** was founded, but way before Pivot and ***Omnea***. We just wanted to have some ***procurement*** tool. There was no procurement tool in place. We looked into Zip, we didn't end up buying.

The second time is when I started at Personio, which was about four years ago. It was also greenfield environment. There was no procurement team, there was no technology in place. We briefly looked into these platforms mainly for intake to have some solution in place. The third one, which is the most recent one, it was about last year, end of 2024, beginning 2025.

We had our intake already, we built it in-house and then we wanted to professionalize a little bit with P2P, purchase to pay, where we obviously as procurement were buying products and services, we were generating purchase orders, but they were just in the limbo and accounting would love to use these purchase order, do some invoice matching, have a fully fledged P2P process.

We were using our in-house built solution. As an ERP, we have Workday. We were looking into specifically something for this P2P part, how we can push our existing purchase orders from one system to Workday so that accounting can use them. In that term, I also spoke with Pivot, that was the first time we looked into Omnea and Zip again.

Client 00:02:46

That's a very helpful background and also somewhat speaks to the broader evolution in the market as each companies were, a few years ago, only looking at this is a new concept and now it's becoming more complex and I suppose more on the point solution side. That sounds good. I guess maybe we can focus on the most recent evaluation as a starting point. I was curious, other than the P2P functionality, were there other criteria that were very important to you in your narrowing process and your evaluation process?

Expert 00:03:20

Of course, price and cost, but that's every evaluation. Another one was user experience. We are a tech company, we provide a very user-friendly product and we love to work with companies that are equal to ours. That's why solutions like Ariba, JAGGAER, Zycus were not even on a short list because for us they're perceived as legacy old tech. We wanted to work with modern tech.

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User experience in terms of the procurement team, how we work with the platform, and very importantly also the request to the stakeholder because these are basically our customers for procurement. They have a very easy, seamless process. That was a big, big focus. Another one was let's say customization. We are very into customizing processes and not working with off-the-shelf solutions and workflows. How I can customize in terms of the user interface and the logic of the platform, that was important.

By user interface I'm referring to, for example, an intake form or when I look at a vendor record, what fields I see, what charts I see. By the logic, this is this orchestration part of these solutions. When I get a request where I'm routing the ticket, who has to approve the logic that the process follows. That was an important one. The integration capabilities, having **a strong API and then preferably native connectors to solutions** or if these native connectors don't exist, again, having an API so that we can build it ourselves and then also how they integrate.

We are a little bit unfortunate because not a lot of solutions integrate with Workday straight away. Back then, there were Workday integrations, but only for the HR module, not for the finance module. That was a thing we realized that a lot of these solutions were integrated with NetSuite, SAP, with Dynamics, but mainly not really would work in finance. I do believe nowadays they do, but back then that was not the case. To recap, user experience, customizability, integration and then costs.

Client 00:05:26
Got you. Those are some I've seen before., especially the customization one seems to be coming up quite a lot. From your perspective, looking at those four key criteria, how would you talk about the differences between those three providers, Zip, Pivot, Omnea? Are they much of a muchness? Do you see major differences? How do you think about them across those four?

Expert 00:05:52
I think if you have nothing and you buy any of these platforms for intake, you'll be good, you'll be fine. It's like all of them will solve the issue of having a seamless intake request and then everything reaches me in procurement. I think all of them do that quite well. The major differences, maybe if I start with Pivot. I spoke with Pivot, again, end of 2024, beginning of 2025. To us, it seems very rudimentary, a little bit surface level. They have an intake request that was great. I always like to say that intake, like getting the request is maybe 15%, 20% of procurement.

All the interesting things and the more complicated things happen once I get the ticket and then I have to stop my work. It didn't seem very focused on that. It was very like this intake that the request interacts with. One thing that we specifically didn't like that much, there was a budget functionality. The budget functionality didn't sync to any platform. There was no allocation engine in the background, it was just a CSV import and then I just have it in Pivot. It was a very surface level complexity of the product.

In terms of Omnea, Omnea was a little bit more deeper, I would say what we've seen. They had a big focus on supplier monitoring TPRM, third-party risk management, **which was quite nice**. They have guided intake. Instead of submitting a form like with ChatGPT, they just chat with a request and then I'm getting something. That's something I haven't seen with Pivot and Zip. That was quite nice. Again, they also started mainly as an intake solution, orchestrating. All of these platforms are going into P2P, third-party risk management cards and everything. The intake solution is fairly fleshed out. I think there was no huge difference. They're all fine, they all do what they need to do.

With Zip, probably the most established and **also the category leader** because they started this intake orchestration thing. Again, intake looked great. At that time, they were showing some AI products, which of course is also interesting to us. During the sales process, there was a big heavy focus on intake, intake, intake. Again, these vendors, I'm telling you, but we're interested, for example, contract management, when we get the request, how would I deal with getting the contract signed?

They have this orchestration layer where I can, for example, integrate to DocuSign, but it's very basic. It's not very in depth or any detail everything that is not this intake portion, but the intake portion they did well. I think if I would probably compare those, I would put Pivot more into smaller companies with less complex environments. Also, with the age, it would make sense for me. Zip, they are definitely going more direction enterprise, back then and nowadays, more like as competition to Ariba and these sorts of platforms.

I have a lot of industry colleagues that use Zip and they also can attest the saying that prices go up and they try to sell you the whole solution. Instead of just intake, you have third-party risk management, you have source to pay, you have P2P and all of this included. Really competition to Coupa or something like that. Omnea I would probably put more into the mid-market, less super enterprise, but more AI-focused solution with this guided buying that looked quite nice and there was a bigger supplier focus with supplier portals, third-party risk management and so on. I'm pretty sure all of these platforms do all these things to some extent, but this is how I would categorize the models.

Client 00:09:51
That's helpful. Interesting to see those differences in where they focus and the approaches and also maturity I suppose too. I'm especially curious to hear what you think about the UX and customization as well as the integration piece. People who have been in your position and

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have done evaluation have told me that, for example, **Omnea has been very good at customization** whereas Zip has had this quite ahead of the pack integration layer like a middleware that they've built. I was curious to hear what you thought about UX, customization and integration between the three. Again, sort of similar, are they much of a muchness or do you think one is better in a certain area? How would you rate against your criteria?

Expert 00:10:39

We are building all our solutions now on our own so maybe I have a more skewed opinion of this. In terms of integration, I would definitely think from what I see that especially Pivot, I'm probably sure that Omnea is similar, they all integrated to the same solutions, DocuSign, Jira, ServiceNow, Vanta for security platform. They all had literally the same integrations. The orchestration layer looked basically the same. I would probably say that Omnea just because Zip is the older company and I'm pretty sure they do.

In terms of this plug-and-play integration orchestration layer, I don't really see a huge difference between Zip and Omnea. Pivot definitely back then had less integrations. A classic Ariba, DocuSign and NetSuite was there. I do believe they integrate more with OneTrust now, all of these platforms. Back then, that was not the case. In terms of orchestration, native integration, I don't think there's a huge difference. They're all the same. In terms of API, that was the problem with Zip. They didn't want to show us really the API documentation. It's also not public, which I'm not a fan of and I told them.

Also an additional charge. They didn't tell me exact pricing, but from what I heard in the industry, it's like $5,000-$10,000 just for the external core for API access, which I was not a fan of. In terms of customizability, how I can customize my interfaces, I felt like **all of these platforms were a little bit weak**. When I talk about customizing my workflow, I get the ticket. It goes to my security team and then an FP&A manager and then I look at it. This is this orchestration logic layer. They're all fine with this. You can do this all yourself. This was okay. It was fine.

In terms of UI and actually the logic of the product, for example, how often I want to update certain records, building custom automations within the product that updates only Zip or Omnea, and also adding new fields, adding new charts, **it felt weak between all of them**. I asked, of course, questions like, "Hey, what about here? Can I add a field? Can I add a chart? Can I change the color?" All of them were like, "No, that's not possible."

I guess for a lot of people this probably is sufficient or they're fine with this. Personally, for me, I would have hoped that there's more customizability for these interfaces. Now if I talk about the intake, this form where I log in as a requester and I submit what I have, this is any old tech, conditional logic forms. This is very old. This was fairly customizable. When I'm referring to me as a procurement manager, I lock into these platforms, I look into my vendor records and I want to see exactly how I want to see it. This was fairly off the shelf. It's not super customized in my opinion.

Client 00:13:49

That's helpful. When you think about the user experience overall for an end user as well as the procurement team?

Expert 00:13:58

For end users, of course what to compare to. The majority of procurement tools are extremely old and ugly. If you go from a Coupa to any of these platforms, your requesters will love it. I talk to a lot of companies that have no solution in place and then it's just per email or some weird old service ticket. If you compare it to that, I think **the user experience for the end user is definitely very nice**. I think if you would compare Zip, Omnea and Pivot from an end user perspective creating these intake requests, there is no difference, honestly.

I would be really confident saying that as an end user, they don't really care exactly what logo it is. It's all conditional form. Knowing how our requesters act in Personio, I don't think they will care that much. As the procurement person, again, I didn't work with those. I saw demos and all these things and what colleagues showed me. I felt like I would be most happy with Omnea from a user perspective. We're not really super enterprise. We're not a huge conglomerate or anything. Zip is really going into that direction a little bit more.

Omnea is a good mix between Zip and Pivot. It's enterprise enough, it offers me enough features, customizability without going this enterprise grade. What I think is also important to note is we only do indirect procurement. We're a tech company, we're not buying metal or screws or wood or food or anything like this. All of this delivery notes, supply chain logistics part of procurement doesn't apply to us. We maybe buy services and software, digital things. For that, a lot of these procurement features are not really relevant, like three-way matches.

I feel personally like Omnea would have been the benefit. From a user experience, if I only evaluate what is possible, I think they're all good. I don't think you can make a bad decision from that perspective. If I would include into my opinion things that I would like to do, but the platform doesn't allow me to. When I was referring to the customization of interfaces, **all of them would be a little bit weak**. What the platform presents me, how it looks, how I can click, I think they all were good.

These are modern companies. I think they all were nice. I know you said you focus on these, but I was a little bit surprised by Levelpath. I genuinely felt **it was quite ugly, which was a little bit interesting because they were like this new AI-native player and on the website**

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it looks weak, but the actual product I felt like was genuinely the ugliest of all of those. The colors, it looks a little bit outdated in my opinion. In terms of just the UI, they're all good. You can't do anything wrong with it, honestly.

Client 00:16:59

Sorry to keep on pushing on this one, but I was just curious, on the level of enterprise features as it relates to the ***procurement*** user, you're saying ***Zip*** is going for the more enterprise segment. ***Omnea*** is a good mixture in the middle. Are there specific things just for me to get a better understanding, specific features or functionalities that suggest to you that it's more enterprise?

Expert 00:17:21

This enterprise argument definitely for Zip comes from a recent hiring and recent push that they did. There was a lot of enterprise procurement leaders that hold transformation offices and so on. That was definitely a big one. Also in terms of deeper integrations into an SAP and so on. In terms of the general products and features, they all offer nowadays. If I look at it today, intake, P2P, supply onboarding and then third-party risk management.

I know Zip has a sourcing feature, for example, which of course is relevant for direct procurement, which for example, I don't believe Omnea or Pivot has yet. They also came out with, I know Zip did it, I'm not sure about Omnea with accounts payable integration, where you pay your invoices from the platform. You have this three-way match with purchase orders. These kinds of things tell me they want to go in that direction as well as with credit cards that they have.

You have to consider, they all started with intake and now they have their other products as well. Now they want everyone to use everything. Before, with intake, the idea was I have SAP, a Coupa or JAGGAER and I just put intake on top of my Coupa because the experience is better, but I still keep my Coupa in place. Now they're pushing for, "Get rid of your Coupa, only use Zip."

I know from various friends in the industry that are definitely bigger that Zip has been pushing tremendously for that in terms of, "Don't use your Coupa, you have to use us for everything." Also trying to sell the whole platform. Pricing went up tremendously unfortunately. It's in an area where you definitely look into ERP solutions in terms of cost or a Coupa or an Ivalua, which I know are not cheap. Just in terms of pricing, it's more in that area nowadays. This is what I know from Zip. I haven't heard anything like that from Omnea specifically or seen anything. Just because of that, I would they're pushing more for this enterprise market.

Client 00:19:29

Understand. I actually did have that question for you around the point solution versus platform a bit later. Since you brought it up, I was curious to hear what do you think? Obviously, you evaluated these tools and now you're working very actively in this industry helping a range of clients on their procurement process. What's your sense of the industry today?

Are we going into a more direction of build out your stack with a range of point solutions that talk to each other and create this cohesive process, obviously tools being more specialist, or is this the end-to-end platform approach something that **companies are finding attractive**? I'd love to get your thoughts there.

Expert 00:20:10

That's a good question. I think it's very dependent on what kind of company you are, your size and what kind of procurement you run. Generally, what I don't believe is that nowadays the modern company would only use an ERP and nothing else. We live in an environment where you have to have your first-party platform that you think will integrate with ERP. You don't have data in silos. Data flows between pools, but you don't work in your ERP, which we don't do. Also with Zip, Omnea, Pivot these platforms, that's what you do.

If you talk about point solutions, there's a lot of procurement that coming out right now and I get a lot of intake for office furniture, no joke, that's really something I got. These are platforms specifically for office furniture. This I think is going to die. It's super niche, really point, just for one specific niche and use case. I don't believe in anything like that for our side, the companies I work for, super small solutions. If I would think about these platforms as an intake, I use it in an intake, I push data into an ERP, yes, I think that makes sense.

Where **I'm a little bit wary** is using just one vendor for every single thing. If I'm a company, old school insurance, nothing techie, older age, that people work with everything Excel-based, I would definitely, and this is what I'm suggesting other people, buy one of these platforms because you have not the technical skill or tech savviness to even understand how this works and how to do it potentially better. I think you can't go wrong with getting a Zip for all of your problems.

I do believe if you come from classic Outlook, Excel which a lot of procurement runs on, you will have an impact, you will have an ROI, **you will have an increase in efficiency** and so on. Definitely not a question. However, I do believe if you just go with these platforms, your procurement will be good, it will be fine, but it will not be exceptional or really, really good because you need this customizability.

Now, you can work with these platforms and build a little on top. If I, for example, would go and take the example of sourcing. As an

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example, Zip's sourcing product, it's fairly new, it's not very old. My thought would be it's probably great, but **it will definitely lack a lot of functionality that a sourcing product like DeepStream** they only do sourcing. It's sourcing for everything. It's still a point solution, it's just for sourcing, but it's not for a specific category or anything. It's not as niche as this furniture example I mentioned.

Having something like Zip and then a DeepStream does make sense, but then again it depends on my own functionality, what I need. I think if I would just use Zip, it's going to be fine. I'm pretty sure you will have functionality that you're missing and that's not even Zip. That's any platform. Personally, what I usually would do in the companies I work for, but then I have to say I exclusively work for technology companies. Obviously, the innovation is a little bit higher and IT security doesn't force me to only use Microsoft product is to build these things.

If I, for example, go ahead and take our vendor monitoring, TPRM that these solutions offer, there are some native integrations, but it's fairly off the shelf. It's fairly what the tool presents me. I can customize a little bit, but I take it as it is. There's not a ton of customization in there, but maybe I want it differently because I have a particular use case. I would either build on top of these platforms or I would just build it entirely myself. We usually do the second round. You could argue it's kind of like a point solution that we do on our own.

Maybe to recap, in less techy, more old school legacy or in the financial industry, healthcare where these thing are quite important, going with these solutions is a good one. I would still 100% advise for building on top of your Zip, using the API and building own solutions to fit your purpose because none of these platforms will. My company's problems are not equal to the roadmap of my vendor.

There's always a conversation about vendor dependence which with these platforms is quite big because once I have my intake, my P2P, my supplier onboarding, my credit cards, they can charge me whatever they want and I have to pay for it because there's no way I can migrate within six months. That's also something I have in mind. That's why I personally wouldn't go for one big platform for everything. It's going to do everything fine, but not exceptional.

If I go with this again build on top of or potentially buy these point solutions. I see, for example, Zip has credit cards. I can use a Zip, I just don't buy the credit cards. I go with something like Navan or Ramp, for example, because the credit card functionality would be better. It's always a question if I will need to use all the products.

For companies that don't have these huge requirements in terms of fintech or healthcare, I think going with just intake at Zip, Omnea, and then having multiple platforms all connected might make more sense. Potentially looking at our cost, **we are tremendously cheaper** that way than with just using Zip for everything. **Our risk of vendor dependence is way lower** as well because we don't have all our eggs in one basket.

Client 00:25:51

That's very helpful. Just to go back to the evaluation a little bit, I've heard some things from other experts in the field around when you're comparing these vendors, there's different experiences and the interaction with the actual individuals, the salespeople, the solutions engineers, the implementation people and so on. I wonder if you could speak to your experience at all about what it was like working with these vendors and how important do you find that in making a decision like this?

Expert 00:26:21

Good question. For us, that's something very important because if **the sales process is annoying**, they're not flexible, I can project this on the entire relationship with the vendor. I will start with this because that was the quickest one. I spoke with the founder directly. We had a couple of calls. It was fairly léger. It was not super strict or extremely formal, which I prefer. I work in tech companies, it's not extremely formal.

For me, what always is a big point, I want to see the solution. I want to look at it, I want to ask, "Hey, can you click this button? What does it do? Can you click into here? Show me the product." I'm not a fan of slides of videos or anything like this. With Pivot, it was quite nice. I can imagine now that they hired more salespeople, it's a little bit different. Back then, I just spoke with the founder, he showed us the product. I had two, three calls with them. That was a good experience.

Zip has the worst experience. I'll go with Omnea first. With Omnea, they've been very respectful, but also respectful to us telling them, "No, thank you, I don't want to work with you anymore." I also know from industry colleagues that Omnea is mainly pushing for Zip customers. That's very interesting to them. There's a lot of bad talking about Zip. I see personally emails and WhatsApp chats and all of this where **people from Omnea are negatively** talking about Zip products, which I'm not a fan because talk how good your product is, don't talk bad about competition.

I had the first interaction with Zip I think six years ago. Since then, they've been renting my LinkedIn inbox. We get a lot of emails from Zip and we already contacted the founder because they don't seem to have a CRM. They will send us an email, "Hey, are you aware of Zip? Do you want to buy our product?" We say no. Two weeks later, someone else sends us the same message.

I also know from friends who are Zip customers, they're also getting messages on LinkedIn to buy Zip and they're like, "Hey, man, I'm a customer already." **I think there's some chaos in the sales org**. In terms of the general sales process I had with them, all nice, respectful

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people. Nobody unfriendly, anything. It's very formal in a sense you talk with an SDR, then you have to set up another meeting with an account executive. You have to set up another meeting with a solution consultant.

Only in the third call you actually get to see the product. This is something I don't like because I don't want to waste three meetings to just end up knowing, "Okay, I don't like the product. It has a core feature that I don't have." That was something very annoying to us. They will send you an interactive demo, but it's not like a demo or anything. It's just a website and you can click. It's kind of like an interactive video. It's not really a demo.

With Zip, **it was very challenging and difficult to get to see the product finally**. They have some content on the website, but whenever we buy software, we want to test it. I want to play around with it myself for maybe one, two weeks, build something myself before I do that. **That was very challenging with Zip**. What they told us, maybe that changed. Maybe it was just the salesperson, but back then they told us they don't give out trial accounts. I have to buy the cat in the box. They don't let me test the product myself.

Client 00:30:07

You were talking about Zip and you covered the interactive demo piece and you said you want to be able to test and try and actually work within the product. I'm assuming some kind of trial.

Expert 00:30:20

That's something Zip told us **they don't offer at** all. I just have to buy the whole product without testing it, without trying it, which I'm not a fan of. Again, with this kind of like email LinkedIn harassment I said. There was another instance for us personally **that had a very bad taste for Zip sales**. I think that was seven, eight weeks ago. It's fairly recent, where we had a salesperson from Zip find our phone number somehow.

The people are nice. **Zip is a little bit difficult to actually** see the product. It reminds me of very legacy old tech. If you are going to buy a Workday, it's the same approach basically. From that I felt Omnea and Zip was a bit easier.

Client 00:31:06

I'm curious to hear, if you recall this and no worries if not, but how they all talk about one another. Not necessarily if it's negative, but I was curious if you recall how Zip talked about Omnea or Pivot talked about Zip or what have you? Did that ever appear in any of your conversations?

Expert 00:31:26

Pivot didn't mention any of these competitors in a negative way. I think we just dropped a name, "We spoke to Zip." That's it. There was no comparison happening, which I thought was nice. Zip didn't talk negatively about competitors. It was mainly Omnea. I recall a conversation I had, it was like, "Ahaha," because **Zip's renewal feature is so bad**.

It's like laughing, joking way but still comparing them, not saying, "Hey, our renewal feature is better because of this functionality and we know this because we have a lot of ex-Zip customers. That's why I'm happy to show you that this works better." It's just like, "Oh yeah, Zip is so bad," in a unprofessional joking way. It was like a conversation like email thread, chat message, something like that. That was the times I recall. The one time this Omnea person was talking about us as a team was a direct conversation where I was not part of, but I got told what happened in the conversation.

Client 00:32:27

It reflects a little bit your experience on an interaction level, it does tell you a little about these companies in terms of what they decide to say or if anything, I suppose. It also makes me think a little bit about, I've been leading up to this question a little bit, but I was curious what you look for in a company outside of the product or offering, so to speak. Obviously, one thing here could be what is the quality and flexibility of the sales interaction?

What is the level of professional integrity? Those are just examples. I'm assuming those things are important to you based on what we've just talked about, but curious to understand what else about the business, the trajectory, the track record, if they have a lot of customers? What else do you look at when you're making a decision like this? Beyond just the technology, what stands out to you?

Expert 00:33:17

I have two examples for Zip once I finish. One thing is definitely customers. I look for customers that are similar to our company. I, for example, wouldn't work with the company I see all the customers are no names out of a manufacturing industry. I would not work with the company. I look for similar customers. I do have to say Zip, Omnea and Pivot, they have good logos where I would feel confident in potentially working with any of these platforms. That's something that's good.

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Definitely the interaction with the salespeople, with the engineers, solution consultant and customer success managers, how easy it is to get a hold of them. I don't like when a salesperson only talks to me when they want to sell me something. When I have an account executive, I expect that it just answers general questions so it guides me to another person. I do work with a couple of companies where the salesperson only wants to sell me, never talks to me besides that. I got the feeling from Zip a little bit like this, but we never became customers. I cannot confidently say this.

In terms of what I like to look is roadmap and then new features and the speed of innovation and building. I like to have a vendor that iterates and improves the platform over and over again. With the majority of platforms I work directly, I always request at least one-time view into the roadmap. Again, I didn't get to the point of seeing the roadmap of these platforms, but I see they're developing solutions. That's something that's quite nice.

I would say besides the product, the technology itself, definitely their interaction with the folks, support, how helpful they are, how fast they are to reply. I don't know how to call this, but willingness to make it work for me. I have an example, it's not a personal one, but from an industry colleague. I'll try to keep it general because of the rules here. When the product doesn't work, I would say, "Hey, I feel like I'm not getting the value out of the product, out of Zip."

I feel like I can do a little bit more with it. I would expect the company to be like, "Hey, listen, we'll give you a solution engineer for two days. He's going to maybe reimplement you or look at your process and try to get more value out of it." That's something I would expect. I know from colleagues, they will either sell you more implementation for money or it's going to be, "Oh, let me talk to your CFO so he understands the value of the product." There is no really real mitigation and solution of the actual core issue.

I don't think **the product works so well** for me. It's just upselling or, "Let me talk to someone higher than you," which I'm not a fan of. I do expect that the vendor works with me hand in hand and gets the majority out of the platform without charging me for every single interaction. For something like an implementation, obviously you pay for this, but the ongoing relationship.

I know Zip is a little like, "Give me money." I don't know how Omnea and Pivot works in that. One thing that also goes a little bit back to the previous questions, it's also Zip's focus. Zip has a lot of customers. I never met a Pivot customer. I know two, three Omnea customers. All the other industry colleagues are Zip or Coupa or some legacy tool. Zip has been recently having crazy pricing like, "Hey, spend about the higher end of six figures for the whole platform."

I'm not talking about huge conglomerates, I'm talking about companies similar to ours. Very high offers, very high pricing and then very fast to just cut it by 60%. This, "Hey, I'm just going to try to charge you as much as possible," and then, "Oh, I just gave you 70%." DocuSign does this extremely bad. From a company that sells to procurement people, I would not expect this.

I heard there's multiple times where in recent months pricing went up extremely high and **renewal has been painful for existing customers**, try to sell a lot and it's like this, "Hey, I'm charging you $500,000." Eventually I just pay like $100,000. Don't try to charge me $500,000 if you can make $100,000 work. That's like this trust during the sales process that I wouldn't have. When we spoke with them, they also went in with both Omnea, Zip, it was about mid six figures for their intake, not even the whole platform. I know that people pay high five figures to low six figures for these solutions.

Client 00:38:06

From what I understand, not knowing industry very well, I understand that procurement is not a massive space, especially in Europe, and people do talk to one another and this kind of news will make its way around. That's interesting that **it's a bit of a painful experience**. Those other factors are very interesting and very helpful.

I was curious because you mentioned it earlier as well. I think you said that Zip was bringing on enterprise people and transformation people and so on. Do you care about the talent in the business and people that are "impressive" procurement experiences and do you care about things like the amount of money fundraised? I'm just curious about those two items too. Does that factor into that criteria outside of the product that we were just talking about?

Expert 00:38:59

The amount of funding **I do believe nowadays is a little bit of a negative for us**. I had this conversation just recently where a lot of industry folks are thinking maybe something. Zip had the last funding around 2024. That's almost two years ago. Money dries up. VC money is not as cheap. Now they're hiking up prices to make a profit. I think that's what's probably going on.

Nowadays we do believe that it's probably not a huge benefit of having a lot of funding and not being profitable. That's nothing I pay attention a lot. Of course, if I compare a Zip or Omnea with a Pivot, obviously I will trust them a little bit more because **the risk of Omnea maybe going bankrupt** is a little bigger. Working in tech, you mainly work with companies that are unprofitable, so it's not unseen.

In terms of the talent, **I am too wary of these companies** that all of them are founded by salespeople or non-procurement practitioners. I'm generally not a fan of this because a salesperson doesn't know my process better than a procurement person. However, I know they all hire

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eventually procurement experts and I know Zip hires a lot of procurement professionals in their implementation team, which I think is a good approach. At least hiring this talent in not super high ups, but the people in the trenches doing the groundwork, implementing, I think **that's quite respectable**. I heard from all these two companies that they do this.

When I talk about something like Zip hiring industry experts as transformational leaders, I couldn't care less because these are people from huge manufacturing companies. It doesn't interest me that much. If they would hire someone from companies similar to mine, that would be more interesting. If they hire some old guy from Procter & Gamble, I don't really care about them. That's not that interesting.

Maybe another positive thing, ***Omnea*** not that much. ***Zip*** is sponsoring a lot of ***procurement*** content on events, webinars, Vertice as well, but that's a different solution. Vertice and Zip are definitely the behemoths in that industry. They're sponsoring everything. I've been on a couple of webinars from Zip or on events sponsored by them and I have the feeling they try to promote procurement and it's not really interesting to them if their customers are not. I'm not a Zip customer and I'm quite critical of Zip as you might have heard, but they still are fine with me joining a webinar sponsored by them. That's definitely something I respect.

I know from non-procurement-related companies that I was, for example, not allowed to go in a conference that was sponsored by a Personio competitor. Something like this I'm not a fan of. Zip are quite nice in this. As a side note because I just remembered, of course it's important to me that there is procurement talent working at the org and guiding them a little bit through it so that they understand if they're listening to me. All of them are founded by non-procurement people. I'm not a fan of this, but I can't change the founders.

Client 00:42:05

Exactly. That's fascinating. That's always interesting, too, the community point at the end that you made as well about the webinars and so on. I think we can get to the final question. This is just pure opinion from your side and just based on your experiences. I know you're really up to speed on the industry, but I was just curious to hear what do you think each of these guys needs to do to be competitive going forward?

Again, it's dealer's choice if you want to talk about product or you want to talk about reputation or hiring. Especially in the European market I'm very curious about. What do you think? It's just totally opinion and pie in the sky is interesting. You don't need to get a "right" answer.

Expert 00:42:56

That's a really good question. In terms of competitors, I do think none of these platforms do it is utilizing the data they have. If you think about this, every tool is based on four areas. It's the interface, it's the logic, how the product works, the brain, the connectors, how does it integrate to other platforms, and a database. All of them have the same interface, have the same database, have the same connector. That's so difficult to build.

Something like, for example, Tropic, while not being fan of their products itself, big fans, they have a lot of data about benchmarks. Again, we build our own system. I can rebuild a Workday connector and an intake. I can't rebuild having two billion in cost data. I cannot access this. Someone like Omnea, Pivot and Zip, they have lots of customers and they have the data, how much people are spending, they have how long cycle times are.

Specifically for me as IT procurement manager, having benchmarks for software products is quite interesting. I cannot access it. Building out this data data platform and maybe offering it as another service, as benchmarks, a couple tries, I think that that can be a competition. Zip, Omnea and Pivot, I don't think they should all go to enterprise. I'm not sure about Pivot's strategy, but to me it feels like they're comfortable in this smaller mid-market area, like Personio, up to 2,000-3,000 employees. They're comfortable in that area.

I think that's probably a good reason to work with them and compare it to something like Zip that charges me probably 4X the amount. What I've been missing a little bit, and I'm not sure if they would do it, is this customization. I'm a big Claude fan, Claude Code and these kind of things. I do believe they should be integrating more in these platforms.

I know they want you to be within Zip and don't want to work outside of Zip, so I'm not sure they're going to do it. Having maybe deep integrations with more AI providers and having higher customizability would be a big reason for me to be competitive. Again, with these platforms, I get the scalability, the security, the integrations off the shelf, which is helpful. Yeah, that's pretty much it. Again, I'm not using any of those because I would just do it myself and we're running well with this. Thinking about other companies more or less like this.

Client 00:45:32

Really interesting. You just talked about customization and Claude. What's your view on agents and the AI features in the workflow? Is that something that you think the European market is ready for that? Do you think that until there's more proof and traction and so on, this is not an area that buyers really care about? What do you think?

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Expert 00:45:59

I wouldn't necessarily say European or US. If you look at token counts of LLM, Germany, for example, very, very far ahead. I feel like Spain have Mistral AI and Pivot is French. I think they're also quite far in this. If you look at energy, France is a good country to build data centers. The AI features I've seen in these platforms, I do think the European market is looking for that and would like to have them, as long as there is of course a value. Just having an AI feature on top of my Zip request and **it will just summarize it for me is useless to me**. Having something like the guided buying that Omnea has, that's something where I say that makes sense. That's interesting.

The agents that, for example, Zip developed were very bolted on, in my opinion, where it's not deeply embedded into the process and they all required manual interaction. I have to click a button, I have to wait and then I get an output. I don't think there's a tremendous amount of value in this. I would say if it's European or U.S. customer, it doesn't really matter. Something like Levelpath, for example, they pride themselves as AI native, but what I've seen was just like little AI chatbots. It's not really embedded.

If we take an example of contract management, for me, AI native would mean I upload a contract, they parse the contract and they will create red lines for me automatically. They just had a chatbot, I have to chat with it, ask it, prompt it, and then I get red lines in my chat interface. That's more bolted on and I don't think buyers are so keen on that. If it's really embedded into the product, I do believe 100% there is value.

Of course, it's a different pricing factor and that's another conversation if you can pay for it. If it's European or U.S., 100% both are looking for it. Being German, data privacy is a big one and preferably everything is hosted in the EU. From that perspective, Pivot and Omnea would be definitely the solutions I would nowadays prefer. Because Omnea is British, Pivot is for French, Zip is U.S. Just from that, nowadays we're definitely looking a little bit more into buying European and Zip would be the lesser one.

In terms of AI, as long as there's an actual benefit. It's not bolted on. It actually makes my life easier. Of course, people are going to buy it if it makes sense. If there's a business case and they can pay for it. If you just sell me 50 agents just slapped on top and I have to pay for it $50,000, no way. In terms of Claude and these things, again, they should have native connectors, MCPs, but that's a different conversation.

Client 00:48:58

Really interesting and I really enjoyed our conversation. Thank you so much for all the detail and your honesty. Thank you so much for your time today.

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